Part 1: Original Draft

Your latest pasted draft. Wording preserved; paragraph spacing formatted for readability.

As a new immigrant, I always ask myself: why do I come to America? In simple words, because of the American dream - everybody has an equal chance to win. Equal chance is the substantial factor of the reason why Americans are willing to challenge themselves no matter how arduous the task is. This leads to all the valuable ideas and works for human progression made by Americans. However, lots of Americans have a work balanced life by cultivating their own interests in downtime. "To be of use" by Marge Piercy is a poem that describes types of people who produce valuable works for the world. For example, Piercy appreciates people who persevere, collaborative and are self-motivated. "Leisure" by W. H. Davis is an ironic poem that satirizes the life which has no downtime for leisure is poor. Author Marge Piercy presents perseverance and committed work as valuable; however W. D. Davis complicates this idea by warning that a life centered only on productivity is empty and stressful when people lose time to appreciate nature.

In "To be of use", Marge Piercy communicates a key idea of American culture, which is that perseverance creates works that are meaningful to the world. He starts the poem by appreciating people who "jump into work headfirst". By admiring people who “jump into work headfirst”, Piercy presents meaningful work as something people are willing to embrace. Their readiness to begin a new work suggests that motivation comes from their own commitment rather than pressure from others. Therefore, it indicates that these people are self-motivated. Because perseverance is used to describe people who have willpower to do work by themselves and improve their works, this is exactly the group of people who are appreciated by the author. The author also appreciates another group of people "who do what has to be done, again and again", that indicates these people are able to master their work repeatedly. Because their persistence continues even after their initial enthusiasm has faded, perseverance is directly related to this group of people. Beginning a task with enthusiasm is easier than continuing even after excitement has faded. Finally author Piercy addresses how work is meaningful for the world by stating that, "Hopi vases that held corn, are put in the museum." These ancient clay jars used by Native Americans to store and carry liquids, are originally made to use. Because they are well made, they become art and put into the museum. Thus this indicates that works are meaningful because if people do their work with great perseverance and motivation, these works will be used and remembered forever like the hopi vases.

Although Piercy proposes that Americans do need the sense of tension, Davis reminds us that Americans also need to make time for enjoying nature due to the busy and stressful life they have. This is reinforced by author from using repetitions of "no time". The author repeats "no time" 7 times in the poem and states that people have no time to "stand beneath boughs" and see "streams full of stars". "Boughs" and "stars" are all natural scenarios. At the end of the poem, the author displays life is "a poor life if, full of care/ We have no time to stand and stare". By calling the existence of “a poor life,” Davis suggests that a person can fulfill daily responsibilities yet still lack

a satisfying life. Here, “full of care” suggests being consumed by worries in everyday life, leaving little attention for the beauty nearby, which is further explained when people have "no time to stand and stare". As a result this type of life being described is refused by the author because he describes it as "poor". In other words, author Davis believes people need to make time for seeing natural scenarios and experiencing nature in order to live a full life.

Together, the poems suggest that Americans should value both meaningful work and the ability to experience life. This can be seen when self-motivated and persevering people contribute useful work to the world. Also, another equally important point, people also need to experience nature, can be seen when author W. D. Davis categorizes life with no time to see beauties of nature as a poor life. In world today, significance of downtime is emphasized by researchers Patricia Albulescu and Irina Macsinga in their "Give me a break! A systematic review and meta-analysis on the efficacy of Micro-breaks for increasing well-being and performance" on August 21, 2022. They study effects of short breaks on people's performance of work. They found out that downtime help people to perform better in work afterward by reducing fatigue, and longer break improves more. Instead of seeing downtime as waste of time, it actually supports people's long term perseverance and meaningful work. Overall, challenging ourselves and consistent working are still important; however, people are not machines, so people also need some downtime.

Part 2: Revised Version

Assistant revision focused on commentary, integrated evidence, and reduced repetition.

Meaningful Work and a Full Life

As a new immigrant, I often ask myself why I came to America. One answer is the American dream: the belief that opportunity and hard work can lead to a better life. This belief encourages people to challenge themselves and create things that benefit others. However, building a better life also means having time to enjoy it. Marge Piercy's poem "To be of use" values people who approach necessary work with energy and commitment. In "Leisure," W. H. Davies questions whether a busy life is truly fulfilling when people cannot pause to appreciate the world around them. Although Piercy presents perseverance and useful work as sources of satisfaction, Davies complicates this idea by suggesting that achievement alone cannot make life meaningful if people lose the ability to enjoy everyday beauty.

In "To be of use," Piercy presents perseverance as valuable because it allows people to contribute something useful to the world. Her admiration for those who "jump into work head first" suggests that meaningful work begins with a willingness to become fully involved. Rather than waiting for someone else to take responsibility, these people commit their own energy to the task. Yet starting with enthusiasm is only part of that commitment. By praising people who complete necessary work "again and again," Piercy shifts attention from the excitement of beginning to the patience required to continue. Repetitive tasks may bring little immediate recognition, but doing them reliably meets needs that do not disappear when the work becomes boring or difficult. This connection between effort and usefulness becomes clearer through the "Hopi vases that held corn." Although these objects are now displayed in museums, Piercy emphasizes that they originally served a practical purpose. Their value comes from more than being admired: they were made to meet people's everyday needs. The vases suggest that ordinary work can be worthy of respect because of what it provides for others. Through these examples, Piercy offers a way to understand success beyond personal recognition, showing that satisfaction can come from making a dependable contribution.

While Piercy emphasizes the satisfaction of useful work, Davies warns that constant busyness can keep people from enjoying life. The repeated phrase "no time" makes each missed experience feel like part of a larger pattern. People pass through a world filled with beauty, yet their attention remains occupied by other demands. When Davies describes "streams full of stars," the image suggests that something as ordinary as sunlight on water can reward a moment of attention. Enjoyment does not always require an expensive vacation or a major achievement; it can come from noticing what is already nearby. Calling a hurried existence "a poor life" therefore challenges the idea that a full schedule necessarily means a rich life. A person may fulfill responsibilities while still missing experiences that make those efforts worthwhile. The phrase "full of care" suggests that

worry consumes the attention people could give to their surroundings. Davies's concern is not simply whether people take enough breaks to work efficiently afterward. His poem suggests that the ability to appreciate beauty has value in itself. From this perspective, work becomes less fulfilling when it leaves no room to experience the life it is meant to support.

Together, the poems suggest that the better life promised by the American dream should include both useful contributions and time to enjoy the world. Piercy helps explain why commitment matters, while Davies raises the question of what that commitment should ultimately make possible. Modern research also supports taking people's need for rest seriously. In their 2022 review, "Give me a break!," Patricia Albulescu, Irina Macsinga, and their colleagues found that short breaks reduced fatigue and increased energy, although the overall improvement in work performance was not statistically significant. These findings suggest that rest deserves attention because it supports people's well-being, even when it does not clearly increase productivity. For me, this balance changes what it means to pursue the American dream. I want my effort to lead to useful work, but I also want enough time and attention to enjoy the life I am building.

Sources for the revised version

Piercy, Marge. “To be of use.” Poetry Foundation.

Davies, W. H. “Leisure.” Representative Poetry Online, University of Toronto Libraries.

Albulescu, Patricia, et al. “'Give me a break!' A systematic review and meta-analysis on the efficacy of micro-breaks for increasing well-being and performance.” *PLOS ONE*, vol. 17, no. 8, 31 Aug. 2022, e0272460. doi:10.1371/journal.pone.0272460.